

RODRIGO GONZALES ZUAZO

Environmental Economist

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Economics of tropical deforestation, ecosystem-service feedbacks to the economy, non-market valuation, satellite-based causal inference, and conservation finance. Bolivia and its unique ecosystems are my empirical setting.

EDUCATION

Master of Arts in Sustainable International Development, Brandeis University 2023 – 2025
Heller School for Social Policy and Management, Waltham, MA, United States

- Fully funded through the Joint Japan/World Bank Graduate Scholarship, as one of only two Latin Americans selected in a global cohort of more than 120 scholars and the sole Bolivian awardee since 2017.
- Thesis, *Cultural Consensus on Environmental Conservation Programs. Mechanisms Behind a Randomized Controlled Trial in Rural Bolivia*, supervised by Prof. Ricardo Godoy.

Licenciatura (BA) in Economics, Universidad Mayor de San Andrés 2017
La Paz, Bolivia

- Undergraduate thesis graded 100/100 with a mention of excellence; IDH Research Scholarship and LACEA Scholarship.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Environmental Economist, Conservation Strategy Fund (CSF) 2025 – present
Santa Cruz, Bolivia. Research and policy analysis for conservation in Bolivia and Latin America

- Lead economist for conservation economics research, using non-market valuation, econometrics, structural modeling, and M&E in projects with partners including AFD, the IDB, UNDP, GIZ, WCS, and SERNAP.
- Manage studies through their full cycle, from survey design and fieldwork to technical reports and policy recommendations.
- Presented a sole-authored conference paper at the Conference on Nature and the Macroeconomy (Central Bank of Chile, CETEx-LSE, SUREAL-Zurich).

Conservation Research Assistant, Purdue University 2024
Field research in rural Bolivia, with Prof. Jonathan Bauchet

- Designed and implemented household surveys for a post-RCT study on environmental conservation, with cultural consensus analysis in R and data processing in Stata.

Researcher, Trade and Labor Markets, CIESS Econométrica 2017 – 2019
La Paz, Bolivia

- Applied microdata research with pseudo-panel models, simultaneous-equation logit, and Shapley decompositions; harmonized Bolivia's household survey series (1989–2018).
- Output from this period includes two peer-reviewed articles, five conference presentations, and the Central Bank of Bolivia's Best Research Paper Award.

POLICY EXPERIENCE

Principal Economist, Real Sector, Ministry of Economy and Public Finance 2021 – 2023
La Paz, Bolivia

- Led real-sector macroeconomic analysis and the evaluation of the National Development Plan, the Fiscal-Financial Program, and the State Budget.
- Ran policy-scenario simulations in coordination with the Central Bank of Bolivia.
- Integrated Bolivia's Nationally Determined Contributions into economic policy and represented the country before the IDB and ECLAC on decarbonization.

SELECTED CONSULTING

Inter-American Development Bank (IDB) 2026
Sustainable and productive finance for micro, small, and medium enterprises in Bolivia

United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) 2025
Biodiversity indicators aligned with the CBD Global Biodiversity Framework, with fieldwork in the Bahamas

PUBLICATIONS AND WORKING PAPERS

Peer-reviewed articles

- Gonzales, R.**, Malky, A., and Gonzales, L. (forthcoming). “The Extensive Trap: How Deforestation Undermines Productivity and Macroeconomic Stability in Bolivia.” *Land and Ocean Series*, CETEx, London School of Economics.
- Molina, J. M. and **Gonzales, R.** (2019). “Trade Exposure and Labor Earnings in Bolivia: Worker Level Evidence.” *Latin American Journal of Economic Development (LAJED)*, 31, 9–30.
- Gonzales, R.** and Molina, J. M. (2017). “On Graduation from Fiscal Procyclicality: The Case of Bolivia.” *Latin American Journal of Economic Development (LAJED)*, 27, 39–56.

Working papers and other research

- Gonzales, R.** (2026). *Productivity, Deforestation, and the Extensive Trap. A Structural Macro Model for Bolivia*. Presented at the Conference on Nature and the Macroeconomy, Central Bank of Chile – SUREAL (U. Zurich) – CETEx (LSE), Santiago de Chile.
- Gonzales, R.** (2026). *The Relationship Between Deforestation and Productivity in Farmlands in Bolivia*. Mimeo prepared for Fundación FAUTAPO.
- Gonzales, R.** (2025). *Cultural Consensus on Environmental Conservation Programs. Mechanisms Behind a Randomized Controlled Trial in Rural Bolivia*. Master’s thesis, Brandeis University.
- Gonzales, R.** (2022). “Evolution of Economic Activity,” chapter 2 in the 2022 *Report on the Bolivian Economy (Memoria de la Economía Boliviana)*. Ministry of Economy and Public Finance.
- Gonzales, R.** (2020). *Informality and Poverty in Bolivia: The Trade Boom and Its Aftermath*. Bolivian Economists’ Meeting, Central Bank of Bolivia. **Best Research Paper Award**.

PRESENTATIONS AND ACADEMIC SERVICE

- Paper presenter and invited discussant, Conference on Nature and the Macroeconomy, Central Bank of Chile, Santiago de Chile, August 2026.
- Referee, Bolivian Conference on Economic Development, 2026.
- Five conference presentations on trade, labor markets, and fiscal policy, 2017–2020.

HONORS AND AWARDS

- Joint Japan/World Bank Graduate Scholarship, 2023. One of two Latin American recipients in a global cohort of more than 120 scholars, and the sole Bolivian awardee.
- **Best Research Paper Award**, Central Bank of Bolivia, 2020.
- IDH Research Scholarship and LACEA Scholarship, UMSA.

TECHNICAL SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

Methods	Causal inference and quasi-experimental design, panel econometrics, randomized controlled trials, household survey design, macro-ecological and input-output modeling
Software	R (advanced), Stata (advanced), L ^A T _E X, Julia, Python (intermediate), EViews, Survey Solutions, Kobo
Spatial data	MapBiomass, MODIS, NDVI, CHIRPS, QGIS, ArcGIS
Visualization	ggplot2, Tableau, Flourish Studio
Languages	Spanish (native), English (C1, full professional proficiency)

REFERENCES

Prof. Ricardo Godoy
Brandeis University
Master’s thesis supervisor

Prof. Jonathan Bauchet
Purdue University
Field research supervisor

Alfonso Malky
Conservation Strategy Fund
Regional Director